

Witchcraft Paper

HIST-103 | The Emergence of Modern Europe

Instructor: Dr. Lindsay O'Neill

Term: Fall 2026

Assignment Summary

Grade weight:	20%
Start date:	2026-08-25
Due date:	2026-11-10
Group project:	No

Overview (Assignments section)

This 4 page paper will ask you to read a number of primary sources detailing early modern witchcraft trials and to pick a prompt to make argument about what you read. You will turn it in via your TA's Brightspace. See Brightspace for prompts.

Related Mentions

- This 4 page paper will ask you to read a number of primary sources detailing early modern witchcraft trials and to pick a prompt to make argument about what you read. You will turn it in via your TA's Brightspace. See Brightspace for prompts.
- to engage with these terms. You cannot make up these quizzes, but your lowest score
- will be dropped.
- Sleep Paper -20%
- This 4 page paper will ask you to use readings on early modern sleeping patterns to
- make an argument about primary sources and/or life in early modern Europe. You
- will turn it in via your TA's Brightspace. See Brightspace for prompts.
- Witchcraft Paper - 20%
- This 4 page paper will ask you to read a number of primary sources detailing early
- modern witchcraft trials and to pick a prompt to make argument about what you read.
- You will turn it in via your TA's Brightspace. See Brightspace for prompts.
- Mid-term - 20%
- The midterm will include ten of the identification terms (I give a definition and you
- give the term, just like the quizzes) and one longer essay (you will be given five
- Nov 3: Witchcraze!: Witches in Early Modern Europe
- Nov 5: Rewriting the Book of Nature: The New Science & New Knowledge
- Nov 6: Readings for Section:

- Brian Levack, The Witchcraft Sourcebook, Chaps 36-44, 46-47
- 103.Levack.36
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.37
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.38
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.39
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.40
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.41
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.42
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.43
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.44
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.46
- PDF document
- 103.Levack.47
- PDF document
- Nov 10-13: Enlightenment
- Nov 10: Absolute Power: Experiments in Rule
- Witchcraft Paper Due
- Nov 12: The Enlightenment: Thought Experiments
- Nov 13: Readings for Section
- Excerpt: John Locke, Two Treatises of Government (1689)
- Excerpt: Rousseau, The Social Contract (1762)
- Enlightenment Primary Source Activity [Ungraded, but counts towards participation.
- 103.Act.Enlightenment1
- Word Document
- Nov 10: Witchcraft Paper Due
- Witchcraft & Daily Life Paper
- Using the Levack primary sources, examine the gender breakdown between the

- accused and the accusers. Are male witches treated the same or differently? Are the
- accusers mostly male or female? Why? What does this all tell us about gender
- and/or community during this period?
- Using the Levack primary sources, what do these trials tell us about who had power
- in these societies or how class played a role in the trials and accusations? Do the
- Be sure to explain how your evidence connects to your main point (analyze it). Say
- why this quote or fact supports what you are arguing in that paragraph.
- Your essay grade will benefit from specific references to the class readings. Use the
- documents from Diefendorf, reference the documentaries and the witchcraft trials,
- use Locke, and Rousseau and your activities.
- Avoid using the definitions we give in the id terms for your essay. If you show
- original engagement with the terms it's fine, but don't just say what I put down for
- the definitions. It doesn't show a deep engagement with the material and will most
- probably impact your grade.
- Your essay should have a thesis statement and each body paragraph should include
- at least two pieces of evidence to back up your point. We don't expect you to
- memorize quotes, but refer to specific people, texts, and events to support your
- argument. Be sure to let us know how those people, texts, and events support the
- point you want to make. Don't just write "like John Locke" tell use what Locke did
- to support your point.
- Witchcraft & Daily Life Paper

Prompts (pick ONE)

- be an in-class exam.
- Final Exam - 20%
- The final is the same format as the midterm - 10 identifications and one longer essay.
- This too will be an in-class exam.
- Grading Scale
- A: 100-93; A-: 92-90; B+: 89-87; B: 86-83; B-: 82-80; C+: 79-77; C: 76-73; C- 72-70
- D+: 69-67; D: 66-63; D-: 62-60; F: 59-0
- Aug 25-29: Intro & Black Death
- Aug 25: Introducing the Early Modern World
- Aug 27: The Death of the Dark Ages?: The Medieval Inheritance
- Aug 28: Readings for Section
- of attacking or harming? What does this say about what people valued at the time?
- Using what you read in the Levack primary sources consider this: According to

- their confessions, what appears to tempt people to turn to the devil or witchcraft
- and what does it say about society at the time?
- trials show state power or communal power?
- of attacking or harming? What does this say about what people valued at the time?
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- their confessions, what appears to tempt people to turn to the devil or witchcraft
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- accused and the accusers. Are male witches treated the same or differently? Are the
- accusers mostly male or female? Why? What does this all tell us about gender
- and/or community during this period?
- Using the Levack primary sources, what do these trials tell us about who had power
- in these societies or how class played a role in the trials and accusations? Do the
- trials show state power or communal power?

Due Date & Submission

- [We reserve the right to tweak the prompts and guidelines up to a week before the assignment is due, but we will inform you if any major changes are made]
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Format Requirements

- roadmap to your paper, the body paragraphs should start with a topic sentence that says exactly what your main idea for the paragraph is and has at least two quotes or few specific examples that back up your main idea. See the tips below and the paper rubric for more guidance.
- Pick ONE of the following prompts and use Brian Levack's The Witchcraft Sourcebook (2015) for your evidence:
- Based on what you read in the Levack primary sources: What are witches accused
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- Pick ONE of the following prompts and use Brian Levack's The Witchcraft Sourcebook (2015) for your evidence:
- Based on what you read in the Levack primary sources: What are witches accused

Helpful Hints

- Be sure to have a thesis statement in the introduction that tells your reader what the argument for the paper is and how you will approach it. It should tell us exactly what to expect from the coming paragraphs
- Include direct quotes and/or specific examples from the primary sources and cite them. This is your evidence and an essay is only as good as the support you have for your points. Remember we love direct evidence from primary sources. Your evidence should come from the primary sources, not the abstracts from the beginning. If you think you need to use these instead, ask your TA or the instructor.
- Each body paragraph should have its own distinct topic, which should be stated in the first sentence. Your topic sentence should be centered on an idea rather than being descriptive (Avoid: "Ursula was convicted of witchcraft in 1565"; Go for something like: "Upper class individuals accused of witchcraft were treated as more dangerous than those from the lower classes")
- The best paper should do more than just show us x, y, and z about witchcraft or everyday life (if you just do that and do it well it is probably a B or B+ paper). You should reach for what those points together tell us about society at that time. In the best papers the points should build off each other and cumulate in an overarching point.
- Cite all your evidence. If I can write "How do we know?" in the margin of the paper it means you should cite something - in the paper you can ONLY cite Levack's book or lecture. In-text citations are fine: For example (Levack, 12).
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- Be sure to explain how your evidence connects to your main point (analyze it). Say why this quote or fact supports what you are arguing in that paragraph.

Restrictions

- this paper. If you include other sources without checking with your TA you will be penalized.
- 103.Paper.2.F.26
- Word Document
- Nov 17-20: Enlightenment
- Nov 17: Living in "Enlightened" Europe
- Nov 19: Rumbles of Revolution
- Nov 20: Readings for Section
- Video: Africa & Britain, A Forgotten History, Episode 2: Freedom (50 min)
- Slavery and the African Presence in London Activity [Ungraded but counts towards participation. Due in section]
- 103.Act.Enslaved.F.26
- Word Document
- Nov 24 -27: Revolution
- Nov 24: You Say You Want a Revolution?: The French Revolution
- [If I have enough people who want an in-person lecture I will give one, but if you need to travel you should watch the below videos]
- The Fall of the French Monarchy (10 min)
- We are testing you on your ability to navigate the information provided for you by the class, not your ability to find more information. Avoid the internet and information from other courses.
- University Academic & Support Systems
- Statement on University Academic and Support Systems
- Students and Disability Accommodations:

- USC welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs.
- The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) is responsible for the determination of appropriate accommodations for students who encounter disability-related barriers.
- Once a student has completed the OSAS process (registration, initial appointment, and submitted documentation) and accommodations are determined to be reasonable and appropriate, a Letter of Accommodation (LOA) will be available to generate for each course. The LOA must be given to each course instructor by the student and followed up with a discussion. This should be done as early in the semester as possible as accommodations are not retroactive. More information can be found at osas.usc.edu. You may contact OSAS at (213) 740-0776 or via email at osasfrontdesk@usc.edu.
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Full Syllabus Extract

*Witchcraft & Daily Life Paper Due Nov 10 at 11:59pm via your Tas Brightspace page [We reserve the right to tweak the prompts and guidelines up to a week before the assignment is due, but we will inform you if any major changes are made] Paper: 4pgs, double spaced, should be well written, include a specific thesis that gives a roadmap to your paper, the body paragraphs should start with a topic sentence that says exactly what your main idea for the paragraph is and has at least two quotes or few specific examples that back up your main idea. See the tips below and the paper rubric for more guidance. Pick ONE of the following prompts and use Brian Levack's *The Witchcraft Sourcebook* (2015) for your evidence: Based on what you read in the Levack primary sources: What are witches accused of attacking or harming? What does this say about what people valued at the time? Using what you read in the Levack primary sources consider this: According to their confessions, what appears to tempt people to turn to the devil or witchcraft and what does it say about society at the time?*

Using the Levack primary sources, examine the gender breakdown between the accused and the accusers. Are male witches treated the same or differently? Are the accusers mostly male or female? Why? What does this all tell us about gender and/or community during this period? Using the Levack primary sources, what do these trials tell us about who had power in these societies or how class played a role in the trials and accusations? Do the trials show state power or communal power? Helpful Hints: Be sure to have a thesis statement in the introduction that tells your reader what the argument for the paper is and how you will approach it. It should tell us exactly what to expect from the coming paragraphs. Include direct quotes and/or specific examples from the primary sources and cite them. This is your evidence and an essay is only as good as the support you have for your points. Remember we love direct evidence from primary sources. Your evidence should come from the primary sources, not the abstracts from the beginning. If you think you need to use these instead, ask your TA or the instructor. Each body paragraph should have its own distinct topic, which should be stated in the first sentence. Your topic sentence should be centered on an idea rather than being descriptive (Avoid: "Ursula was convicted of witchcraft in 1565"; Go for something like: "Upper class individuals accused of witchcraft were treated as more dangerous than those from the lower classes") The best paper should do more than just show us x, y, and z about witchcraft or everyday life (if you just do that and do it well it is probably a B or B+ paper). You should reach for what those points together tell us about society at that time. In the best papers the points should build off each other and cumulate in an overarching point. Cite all your evidence. If I can write "How do we know?" in the margin of the paper it means you should cite something - in the paper you can ONLY cite Levack's book or lecture.

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Your essay grade will benefit from specific references to the class readings. Use the documents from Diefendorf, reference the documentaries and the witchcraft trials, use Locke, and Rousseau and your activities. Avoid using the definitions we give in the id terms for your essay. If you show original engagement with the terms it's fine, but don't just say what I put down for the definitions. It doesn't show a deep engagement with the material and will most probably impact your grade. Your essay should have a thesis statement and each body paragraph should include at least two pieces of evidence to back up your point. We don't expect you to memorize quotes, but refer to specific people, texts, and events to support your argument. Be sure to let us know how those people, texts, and events support the point you want to make. Don't just write "like John Locke" tell use what Locke did to support your point. Do NOT use resources beyond the lectures and readings to support your answers. We are testing you on your ability to navigate the information provided for you by the class, not your ability to find more information. Avoid the internet and information from other courses. University Academic & Support Systems Statement on University Academic and Support Systems Students and Disability Accommodations: USC welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs. The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) is responsible for the determination of appropriate accommodations for students who encounter disability-related barriers. Once a student has completed the OSAS process (registration, initial appointment, and submitted documentation) and accommodations are determined to be reasonable and appropriate, a Letter of Accommodation (LOA) will be available to generate for each course. The LOA must be given to each course instructor by the student and followed up with a discussion. This should be done as early in the semester as possible as accommodations are not retroactive. More information can be found at osas.usc.edu. You may contact OSAS at (213) 740-0776 or via email at osasfrontdesk@usc.edu.

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